

POPULAR CULTURES

in South Asia

Film & Text Analysis Guide

AFGHANISTAN

Osama (2003) — Siddiq Barmak

AFGHANISTAN

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PAKISTAN

Manto — Saadat Hasan Manto

PAKISTAN

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Mid-Semester Examination | Open Book | Concept-Based Analysis

Use the texts as evidence — not summaries — to explain South Asian concepts.

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PART 1 • AFGHANISTAN • FILM

Osama (2003)

Dir. Siddiq Barmak | First film made in Afghanistan after the fall of the Taliban

Context & Synopsis

Set in Taliban-controlled Kabul, *Osama* follows a 12-year-old girl whose widowed mother can no longer work under Taliban restrictions. With no male guardian, the family faces starvation. A family friend helps the girl disguise herself as a boy — she takes the name 'Osama' — so she can earn money. She enrolls in a Taliban madrassa and survives until she is discovered and forcibly married to an elderly mullah.

Why this film matters for the course: It was made from *within* Afghanistan, not for a Western gaze alone. It is a rare document of Afghan cultural life under extreme political conditions.

1.1 Gender & Gendered Violence

Gender Performance (Performativity): Drawing on Judith Butler's concept of gender as performance, *Osama* makes explicit what is usually invisible: that gender is not biological but social and enacted. The protagonist does not simply wear boy's clothes — she must perform masculinity entirely: her gait, her silence, her posture, her participation in male rituals at the madrassa. Every moment is a conscious act of performance under the threat of violent exposure.

Gendered Violence: The Taliban's regime is a system of gender-based violence. Women are beaten in the street for showing an ankle. The mother is whipped for appearing in public without a male guardian. This is not incidental violence — it is *structural*, the mechanism through which the Taliban maintains power over the population. The female body is the primary site of this enforcement.

Performing Socially Mandated Gendered Roles: Society — and the Taliban specifically — prescribes rigid roles: women belong in the private sphere, invisible and silent; men belong in the public sphere. The protagonist's disguise is a survival response to these mandated roles. It reveals the arbitrariness of gender division: the same child, in different clothes, occupies entirely different social positions.

Use in an answer on Gender:

'Osama illustrates gender performance through the protagonist's daily embodiment of masculinity under Taliban surveillance. Her performance reveals that gender roles are not natural but imposed — and under the Taliban, failure to perform correctly results in violent punishment.'

Link to broader course concept:

Connect to 'Gendering South Asia': women's bodies as sites where national and political projects are contested. Compare with *Khamosh Pani*: in both, a woman's identity/body is controlled by the dominant political order.

1.2 Power, Surveillance & Punishment

The Taliban in *Osama* operates as what Michel Foucault would call a **panoptic power** — a system of constant surveillance where the possibility of being watched at any moment disciplines behavior even when no one is actively watching. The protagonist must maintain her disguise even when she feels unobserved, because the system has made self-policing automatic.

Religious Authority as Power: The mullah who runs the madrassa represents the fusion of religious and political authority. His power is absolute and unchallengeable. The boys' physical training in the madrassa is simultaneously religious and military — bodies are being disciplined into soldiers and believers. The protagonist is trapped in this machinery.

Punishment as spectacle: When the protagonist is discovered, her punishment (forced marriage) is not private — it is administered as part of a social order. Punishment in the film is always public and exemplary: it is meant to deter others. This is how power reproduces itself.

1.3 Erasure of the Public-Private Binary

The traditional public-private binary allocates women to the **private sphere** (home, family, domestic life) and men to the **public sphere** (work, politics, street). Under this model, even when women are oppressed, the home is theoretically a protected space.

The Taliban collapses this binary in a devastating way: women cannot enter the public sphere, but the private sphere offers no safety either. The mother cannot work; the family starves at home. There is no space — public or private — where women are safe or free. The film visually emphasizes this through cramped interiors and the constant intrusion of Taliban authority into domestic space.

Exam Insight:

When answering questions about borders or territoriality, remember that *Osama* shows how borders operate at the micro-level too — not just national borders, but the border of a woman's home, her body, her visibility in public. The Taliban's power is precisely its ability to control these intimate borders.

1.4 Tracing Agency & Survival

A key question the film raises is: **how do marginalized people exercise agency within extreme structures of control?** Agency here does not mean heroic resistance — it means the small, careful, strategic choices people make to survive.

The protagonist's disguise itself is an act of agency — a refusal to accept starvation passively. The neighbour who helps her, the mother who agrees to the plan, the woman doctor who treats patients secretly — all represent forms of quiet, dangerous agency under oppression.

The film does not offer a triumphant narrative of resistance. The protagonist is ultimately caught and punished. This refusal of easy resolution is itself a political statement: under such systems, individual agency can only go so far. Structural change requires structural intervention.

1.5 Socio-Political History of Afghanistan

To understand *Osama*, you must situate it in Afghan history: **decades of war** (Soviet invasion 1979, civil war 1989–1996, Taliban takeover 1996, US invasion 2001) left Afghanistan's infrastructure, institutions, and civil society devastated. The Taliban emerged from the chaos of the civil war, initially welcomed by some for bringing order but quickly establishing a brutal theocratic regime.

The film is set between 1996–2001. The male breadwinners are absent — killed in war. This is not incidental: war has restructured gender dynamics by eliminating men while the Taliban simultaneously refuses women the right to work. Afghanistan as a country is also **a margin in global geopolitics** — fought over by superpowers (Soviet Union, USA) whose interventions shaped the conditions that made Taliban rule possible.

Key Argument for This Film:

Osama demonstrates that gender oppression is not culturally inherent to Afghanistan but is a product of specific political conditions — conditions themselves shaped by colonial borders, decades of war, and Cold War interventions. The film is therefore not 'about Afghan culture' but about what extreme political power does to gender and culture.

PART 2 • AFGHANISTAN • NOVEL

The Kite Runner (2003)

Khaled Hosseini | Afghan-American author | Published for Western markets

Context & Critical Framing

The Kite Runner is a novel by Khaled Hosseini, an Afghan-American doctor living in California. Published in 2003 (post-9/11), it became a global bestseller. The course does **not** use this text primarily as a story about Afghanistan — it uses it to ask critical questions: *Who tells the story? For whom? What is constructed, amplified, or erased in the process?*

2.1 Framing, Distribution & Reception of Narratives

Framing refers to the choices made in constructing a narrative: what perspective is adopted, what is included or omitted, how events are explained. Framing is never neutral — it reflects the position of the narrator and the anticipated audience.

Hosseini frames Afghanistan through the eyes of Amir, a wealthy Pashtun from Kabul. This is already a specific subject position: not rural, not Hazara, not poor. The story of Hassan (the Hazara servant boy) is told through Amir's guilty perspective, not Hassan's own voice. This is a narrative choice with political consequences: the marginalized character is seen, not heard.

Distribution: Published by a major American press (Riverhead Books), distributed globally in English first. The text entered world circulation as an 'authentic' Afghan story despite being written in English by a diasporic author for a US audience. Compare with *Osama*, made in Dari (Afghan Persian) in Afghanistan — distribution channels shape whose story is heard.

Reception: The novel was received in the US as a window into 'why Afghanistan matters' and 'what Afghans are like.' Post-9/11 American audiences read it through the lens of the War on Terror. This reception context shapes meaning: the same text means different things in Kabul and in Kansas.

2.2 Constructing 'South Asia' for Non-South Asian Audiences

The Universal and the Local: The *Kite Runner* achieved global commercial success by emphasizing themes deemed 'universal': father-son relationships, guilt and redemption, friendship and betrayal. These are human experiences but they are presented in a way that makes Afghanistan the *backdrop* rather than the substance. The local specificity of Afghan culture, politics, and history is reduced to atmosphere.

This is a structural feature of how the Global South enters Western literary markets: texts must translate local experience into idioms legible to Western readers. The cost is complexity. Afghanistan in *The Kite Runner* is legible as 'exotic but familiar enough' — tragic, beautiful, and ultimately understood through Western moral categories (guilt, atonement).

What is constructed: The novel constructs an Afghanistan that is recognizable and emotionally accessible to Western readers. Ethnic and class hierarchies (Pashtun/Hazara, master/servant) are present but not analyzed. The Taliban appears as a villain enabling plot resolution. This is a *simplified South Asia* produced for outside consumption.

'Afghanistan Meets the Amazon' — Key Critical Text

This article examines how *The Kite Runner* was read and reviewed in America. It shows that American readers brought their own post-9/11 anxieties and assumptions to the text — using it to understand 'why they hate us,' to find 'good Afghans,' and to process the War on Terror. The article is evidence that **reception is not passive** — readers actively construct meaning from texts in ways shaped by their own cultural and political context. The novel became a tool of American self-understanding more than Afghan self-expression.

2.3 Margin–Centre Framework in Global Publishing

The global literary marketplace operates on a margin-centre logic. The **centre** consists of English-language publishing houses in New York and London, major literary prizes, and Western critical institutions. The **margin** consists of literature from the Global South — including South Asian literature.

Literature from the margin enters the centre only when it is legible to the centre's values and aesthetic preferences. *The Kite Runner* succeeded in part because it did not challenge Western assumptions — it confirmed them. Afghanistan is backward and oppressive (Taliban), the protagonist is a good man who shares Western values (guilt, individual moral responsibility), and redemption is possible through personal action.

Compare: Manto's short stories were **not** globally celebrated in his lifetime — they were censored locally and unknown in the West. His work did not conform to the centre's tastes. This contrast between Manto and Hosseini is itself a lesson in how the margin-centre framework operates in literary production.

2.4 Diaspora & Transnational Literature

Hosseini is a diasporic author: he left Afghanistan as a child refugee and grew up and was educated in the United States. *The Kite Runner* is therefore a **diasporic text** — produced from the experience of living between two cultures, written across the distance of exile.

Diaspora and authenticity: The novel was widely received as an 'authentic' representation of Afghanistan. But authenticity is contested: Hosseini left Afghanistan as a child; his Afghanistan is partly imagined, reconstructed through nostalgia and research. This does not make the novel dishonest — but it complicates the claim to authentic representation.

Transnationalism: The novel circulates across national boundaries, is read in dozens of languages, was made into a Hollywood film. This transnational flow shapes how Afghanistan is imagined globally. For many Western readers, *The Kite Runner* is their primary — sometimes only — source of 'knowledge' about Afghanistan.

Critical Argument for This Text:

The Kite Runner is less a story *about* Afghanistan than a story *for* Western audiences about their relationship with Afghanistan. Its commercial success reveals the operations of the margin-centre framework in global literary production: the margin's stories are welcomed at the centre only when they can be absorbed without challenge.

PART 3 • PAKISTAN • SHORT STORIES

Saadat Hasan Manto

Urdu short story writer | Partition literature | Obscenity trials | 1912–1955

Who Was Manto?

Saadat Hasan Manto was one of the greatest Urdu writers of the 20th century. Born in Punjab (then British India), he worked in Bombay writing screenplays before migrating to Lahore, Pakistan, after Partition in 1947. In Pakistan, he was tried for obscenity six times — three times in British India, three times in Pakistan — for stories depicting sexual violence, sex workers, and the brutal realities of Partition. He died of alcoholism in 1955, in poverty. He is now recognized as one of the greatest writers of the subcontinent.

3.1 Partition as Backdrop

Manto's stories do not narrate Partition as a grand historical event — they depict it as a lived catastrophe in the lives of ordinary, often marginal people. Partition is the **backdrop**: it is the condition that makes his characters' situations possible — the dislocation, violence, loss, and moral chaos that follow when a society is violently divided.

In stories like *Toba Tek Singh*, *Khol Do*, and *Thanda Gosht*, Partition appears not as a political event to be explained but as a catastrophe to be witnessed. Manto refuses the nationalist narratives of both India and Pakistan — he insists on showing what actually happened to actual people, particularly women and the poor.

This approach makes Manto's work radically different from official commemorations of Partition. He does not celebrate independence. He mourns the human cost — and indicts both communities (Hindu and Muslim) for the violence they perpetrated.

3.2 The Art of Character Writing

Manto's characters are his greatest political statement. He consistently writes characters from the **social margin**: sex workers (*Mozelle*, *Hatak*), pimps, petty criminals, the mentally ill (*Toba Tek Singh*), soldiers, refugees. These are the people erased from respectable literature and from nationalist history.

Humanizing the marginalized: Manto does not sentimentalize his characters or moralize about them. He presents them with complete humanity — their desires, contradictions, humor, and suffering. A sex worker in Manto is not a symbol of social decline: she is a person with a name, a history, and an inner life. This is a radical literary politics.

Character as social x-ray: Manto uses character to reveal social structure. His characters' situations expose the hypocrisies of class, the violence of gender norms, the moral bankruptcy of both colonizers and the respectable bourgeoisie. The character is a lens through which the whole society becomes visible.

3.3 Censorship as a Productive Practice

Censorship is traditionally understood as *restriction* — the suppression of speech. The course framework treats it differently: **censorship as productive practice** means that the act of censoring something reveals what power considers dangerous, threatening, or destabilizing. What is censored tells us as much as what is said.

Manto's obscenity trials are a case study. He was prosecuted for depicting sexual violence (rape of women during Partition) and sex work. The Pakistani state's prosecution reveals the anxieties of a newly formed nation: post-Partition Pakistan needed to construct a moral national identity, and Manto's stories threatened that construction by showing the sexual violence perpetrated *in the name of* that identity.

Manto famously responded: 'If you cannot bear my stories, it is because we live in unbearable times.' His defense of his work was itself a political act — a refusal to let the state sanitize the past.

What the censorship produces: The trials made Manto famous and made his work more widely read. They fixed his identity as a rebel author. They also preserved a record of the state's anxieties. Censorship *produces* meaning — about power, about what societies cannot face about themselves.

Exam Tip — Censorship Question:

If asked about censorship in South Asia, use Manto as your primary example but connect it to Osama: the Taliban's total censorship regime (banning art, music, women's visibility) is a more extreme version of the same logic — the state deciding what representations are acceptable. Both cases show censorship as a political act, not just a cultural one.

3.4 Centre–Margin Framework in Literary Production

The literary establishment of post-Partition Pakistan represented the **centre**: educated, middle-class, morally conservative, invested in building a respectable national literature. Manto occupied the **margin** in multiple senses: his subject matter (the poor, sex workers), his style (unsparing realism, no moral instruction), and his personal life (alcoholism, poverty, illness).

The centre's attempt to censor Manto through obscenity trials was an attempt to maintain its own control over what counted as legitimate literature. Manto's refusal to conform — his insistence on writing the margin's stories — was a direct challenge to centre authority.

The irony: Manto is now canonical. He is studied in universities, translated into dozens of languages, celebrated as a national figure in Pakistan. The margin has been absorbed into the centre — but only after his death. During his life, the centre destroyed him.

Key Argument for Manto:

Manto's work and its reception together constitute a lesson in the margin-centre framework, censorship as productive practice, and the politics of representation. His writing brings the margin to the centre; the centre's censorship reveals its own anxieties; and the stories themselves are primary evidence of what Partition did to real people — especially women and the poor.

PART 4 • PAKISTAN • FILM

Khamosh Pani (Silent Waters, 2003)

Dir. Sabiha Sumar | Partition, Gender, Silence, Islamization

Context & Synopsis

Set in a rural Punjab village in 1979, during the Islamization of Pakistan under General Zia ul-Haq. Ayesha is a devout middle-aged Muslim woman. The audience gradually discovers that she is actually Veero — a Sikh woman who was left behind or abducted during Partition in 1947 and converted to Islam. Her son Saleem becomes radicalized by an Islamist movement. When Sikhs visit the village for a religious pilgrimage, Ayesha's past is threatened with exposure. The film ends in tragedy.

Urvashi Bhutalia (secondary source): Bhutalia's oral history work *The Other Side of Silence* documents real cases of women who crossed the border during Partition — abducted, converted, stranded. The film is in dialogue with this historical scholarship.

4.1 Gendering the Partition

Urvashi Bhutalia's research shows that Partition violence was not gender neutral: women — particularly Hindu, Sikh, and Muslim women — were abducted, raped, and killed as part of communal violence. Families sometimes killed their own women to 'protect honor' before enemy men could reach them. Women's bodies became the terrain on which communal conflict was fought.

Khamosh Pani fictionalizes this history through Ayesha/Veero. Her entire identity has been reorganized by gendered Partition violence: she was either abducted or jumped into a well to escape (the film is deliberately ambiguous) and has lived for thirty years as someone else. The Partition is not history — it is her body, her name, her silence.

Women as markers of communal identity: The choice to target women in communal violence is not random — it is because women's bodies are symbolically coded as the repository of community honor and purity. Converting or violating 'their' women is understood as defeating the community. This logic makes women the primary victims of communal conflict across South Asian history.

4.2 Partition as a Continued Event

The film's central argument — enacted through its structure — is that **Partition is not finished**. Official histories treat 1947 as a completed event: the border was drawn, people moved, nations were founded. But *Khamosh Pani* insists that the trauma, the identities destroyed, and the violence perpetrated in 1947 continue to live in people's bodies and communities decades later.

Ayesha carries 1947 inside her. Every day she lives as 'Ayesha' rather than 'Veero' is a continuation of Partition. The arrival of the Sikh pilgrims in 1979 — thirty-two years later — reopens the wound. This is what 'Partition as continued event' means: the border that was drawn in 1947 continues to divide people, identities, and families in the present.

The 1979 setting is also significant: Pakistan is undergoing Islamization under Zia ul-Haq, and Ayesha's son is being recruited into a religious-political movement. The post-Partition nation is still being defined and contested. Partition's consequences — what kind of Pakistan should exist? — are still unresolved.

1947 in the film:

Partition violence, forced conversion, destruction of pre-Partition identities. Veero becomes Ayesha. The border is written on her body.

1979 in the film:

Islamization, radicalization of youth, communal politics re-erupting. Her son's journey mirrors the nation's continued struggle with identity.

4.3 Silence as Stylistic Device & Reading Silence

The title means 'Silent Waters.' Silence is the film's central aesthetic and political device. Ayesha does not speak about her past — not because she has forgotten but because speech is impossible: to speak would be to risk death (exposure) and to re-live unbearable trauma.

Silence as survival strategy: Ayesha's silence is a performance — like the protagonist's gender performance in *Osama*. It is a continuously enacted suppression of identity in order to survive. The film asks us to read what is not said — the pauses, the averted eyes, the moments of stillness when the past almost breaks through.

Silence as historical condition: The film connects to Bhutalia's research method — oral history means going to women who were told to stay silent and asking them to speak. The women Bhutalia interviewed had kept Partition memories secret for decades. *Khamosh Pani* fictionalizes this silence and asks: what is the cost of carrying this silence for a lifetime?

Reading silence in the exam: When discussing narrative form, note that what texts do *not* say is as analytically important as what they do say. Gaps, omissions, and silences in texts are often sites where ideological pressure is most visible.

4.4 Urvashi Bhutalia & Secondary Sources

Urvashi Bhutalia's *The Other Side of Silence: Voices from the Partition of India* is the secondary academic source for the Pakistan unit. It is an oral history project: Bhutalia interviewed survivors of Partition — particularly women — to recover the stories that official histories erased.

Why secondary sources matter in this course: The course combines popular cultural texts (films, novels, stories) with academic scholarship. Bhutalia gives the historical and analytical framework for reading *Khamosh Pani*. She demonstrates that Ayesha's story is not fictional fantasy — it is a fictionalized version of hundreds of thousands of real cases. This connection between popular culture and scholarship is central to the course's methodology.

Oral history as methodology: Bhutalia's use of oral testimony is itself a statement about the margin-centre framework: women's voices were not in the official archives, not in the nationalist histories. She went to find them. The 'other side of silence' — the title — is precisely what *Khamosh Pani* dramatizes.

Key Argument for *Khamosh Pani*:

Khamosh Pani argues that Partition's gendered violence is not historical but ongoing — living in women's bodies, their silences, and their suppressed identities. The film uses silence as both subject and form: the story of what cannot be said, told through what the film itself refuses to state directly. It is also an argument that 'culture as process' includes the active suppression and recovery of memory.

CROSS-TEXT CONNECTIONS

Using multiple texts in a single answer demonstrates mastery of the concepts. Here are the most powerful cross-text connections:

Osama ↔ Khamosh Pani

Both centre women whose bodies are the primary site of political violence. Both use silence and concealment as survival. In Osama, disguise = survival. In Khamosh Pani, silence = survival. Both refuse triumphant narratives of resistance, insisting on the cost of survival under extreme oppression. Both are about the **erasure of women's identities** by political regimes (Taliban / Partition-era communal violence). Together they show that gendered violence is not specific to Afghanistan or Pakistan but structural to South Asian political history.

Manto ↔ Khamosh Pani

Both deal with Partition and Pakistan. Both refuse nationalist celebration of 1947. Manto writes Partition's violence explicitly — and is censored. Khamosh Pani embeds the same violence in silence and form. Two aesthetic strategies for the same historical wound: one confrontational, one oblique. Both centre women as the primary bearers of Partition's violence. Together they show that **censorship and silence are related phenomena**: what Manto was censored for saying, Khamosh Pani says through not-saying.

The Kite Runner ↔ Osama

Both texts are 'about' Afghanistan, both appeared in 2003, post-9/11. But their framing is radically different. Osama is made *in* Afghanistan, in Dari, from within Afghan experience — though it also circulates internationally. The Kite Runner is written in English, in America, *for* Western markets. The comparison reveals how the same subject (Taliban-era Afghanistan) is constructed differently depending on **who speaks, from where, and for whom**. Osama offers no redemption; The Kite Runner does. Why?

Manto ↔ The Kite Runner

Both face questions of censorship and reception, but in opposite directions. Manto was censored for speaking truth to power in his own society. The Kite Runner was *celebrated* for making South Asia palatable to the Western centre. Manto refused to make his work comfortable. Hosseini (structurally, not in terms of intention) made his work comfortable. The difference in their reception reveals the **margin-centre framework in literary production** and the politics of what stories get told.

EXAM ANSWER TEMPLATES

Since the exam is concept-based, every answer should: **(1)** define the concept, **(2)** apply it to South Asia broadly, **(3)** use a text as evidence, **(4)** analyze — do not summarize.

Gender / Gendering South Asia

[Concept: e.g., gendered violence] refers to... In South Asia, this is visible through [historical example: e.g., Partition, Taliban rule]. [Film/text] illustrates this through [specific element: e.g., the protagonist's forced gender performance], showing that [analysis: gender is imposed through political force, not natural]. This connects to [second text/concept] because [link].

Margin–Centre Framework

The margin-centre framework describes how [definition]. In South Asian popular culture, [text] demonstrates this through [example]. The [character/author/narrative choice] occupies the margin because [reason], while [institution/power/audience] represents the centre. This framework helps explain [broader insight about South Asia].

Censorship as Productive Practice

Censorship, understood as productive practice, reveals [definition]. Manto's obscenity trials demonstrate this: he was prosecuted for [specific content], which tells us that post-Partition Pakistani society was anxious about [what the censorship reveals]. Compare with [second example, e.g., Taliban's censorship in Osama]: in both cases, censorship is a political act that produces meaning about [power/anxiety/control].

Partition as Continued Event

Partition is not a finished historical event but a continued trauma because [reason]. Khamosh Pani demonstrates this through [Ayesha's suppressed identity / the 1979 setting / the film's use of silence]. Bhutalia's research confirms this through [oral history methodology / women's testimonies]. Together, these sources argue that [broader claim about memory, trauma, identity in South Asia].

Culture as Process

Culture as process means that culture is [definition — not fixed, continuously made and remade]. [Text] shows this through [specific example: Taliban remaking Afghan gender culture; Islamization remaking Pakistani village life]. This is significant because it means we cannot read [the text] as representing a timeless 'South Asian culture' but rather a [specific political moment / contested cultural formation].

Good luck tomorrow. Remember: the texts are your evidence, not your subject. Answer about South Asia, and use the films and stories to prove your argument.